490.LIFE · DEEPER STUDY · STUDY GUIDE

The End of Counting

Matthew 18:21–35 · Luke 17:3–4 · Colossians 3:13



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New to this? This is one of our Deeper Studies, a long and careful study. If you are just starting out, begin with the five-page short version, The End of Counting, then come back here when you are ready to dig in.

Introduction: The Ledger You Did Not Know You Kept

Nobody decides to become a scorekeeper. It happens to us. Somebody wounds you, and without a single conscious choice a page opens in your heart with their name at the top. Every slight after that gets an entry, and you can recite the entries years later: the words, the room, the look on their face. We are accountants by birth. The ledger is the most natural thing in the world.

Peter was keeping one. That is what Matthew 18:21 is: a fisherman doing arithmetic on grace. "Lord, how often will my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? As many as seven times?" He was not being stingy. The rabbis taught three. Peter doubled it and added one, and seven was a holy number besides. He thought he was aiming at heaven. Jesus answered with a number that mocked the idea of counting, then a story about two ledgers, and then He went to a cross and closed the books for good.

This study puts three passages side by side and shows that they are one teaching:

> **Matthew 18:21–22** *"Then Peter came up and said to him, 'Lord, how often will my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? As many as seven times?' Jesus said to him, 'I do not say to you seven times, but seventy-seven times.'"*

> **Matthew 18:32–33** *"You wicked servant! I forgave you all that debt because you pleaded with me. And should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?"*

> **Colossians 3:13** *"Bearing with one another and, if one has a complaint against another, forgiving each other; as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive."*

Here is the thread that runs through all three. The New Testament has two main words for forgiving, and neither means what we usually mean. The first, **ἀφίημι (*aphiēmi*)**, is the word in Peter's question and in the parable: to *send away*, to release, to let go. The second, **χαρίζομαι (*charizomai*)**, is Paul's word in Colossians and Ephesians, built on *charis*, grace: to forgive the way you give a gift. One tells you what forgiveness does to the debt. The other tells you where it comes from. Together they are the whole gospel of this study: a debt released, because a gift was received.

So: **Part One is the number**, what Jesus did to Peter's math. **Part Two is the story**, two ledgers and the moment a forgiven man grabs a throat. **Part Three is the source**, why you cannot forgive by trying, and where the supply comes from. A handful of Greek words along the way, none for decoration. Each one

changes what you do with the name at the top of your page.

Part One: Seventy Times Seven, The Number That Ends Numbers

> **Matthew 18:22** *"Jesus said to him, 'I do not say to you seven times, but seventy-seven times.'"*

Some Bibles read "seventy-seven times," others "seventy times seven." The Greek, *hebdomēkontakis hepta*, can carry either, and chasing the exact figure misses the point as badly as Peter nearly did. Either way the number is chosen to be uncountable in practice. Try it. Resolve to forgive a man exactly 490 times and not once more. You will need a notebook. Every wound becomes an entry, and by offense three hundred you are a full-time bookkeeper of your own pain, nursing each slight because you need it for the count. Jesus picks a number so big that the only sane response is to throw the notebook in the fire.

And He is quoting. In Genesis 4:24 a swaggering man named Lamech, Cain's descendant, boasts that he will avenge himself "seventy-sevenfold." He took the mark of mercy God had put on Cain and twisted it into a trophy of revenge. That number sat in the text for thousands of years like a scar. Then Jesus picks it up, holds Lamech's number of cursing in His hand, and turns it into a number of blessing. Lamech multiplied vengeance. Jesus multiplies mercy. Peter has just heard the kingdom of heaven sing over the grave of the kingdom of getting even.

Now look at the verb, because the English has flattened it. When Peter asks how often he must "forgive," the word is *aphiēmi*, and it is not primarily a feeling word at all.

ἀφίημι *(aphiēmi)*

translated "forgive" in Matthew 18, the Lord's Prayer, and Luke 23:34. Literally, to send away; to release; to let go

ἀπό (apo)

"away from, off"

Separation. Distance opened between two things that were bound together.

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ἵημι (hiēmi)

"to send, to let go"

To release what you were holding. The same verb is used for a fever leaving a body and for a ship casting off its lines.

Payoff: Forgiveness in the New Testament is first of all a *release*. Jesus uses this exact word when a paralytic's sins are "sent away" (Matthew 9:2), when the disciples "leave" their nets (Matthew 4:20), and when He cries from the cross, "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34). It is the language of a creditor opening his hand. Nobody is told to manufacture warm feelings. You are told to let go of the debt. The feelings, when they come, come more easily to an open hand. (A caution for careful students: word roots are a guide, not a proof. Here the anatomy and the New Testament usage agree.)

Two things follow. If forgiveness is release, it assumes a real debt; you cannot let go of a debt that does not exist, so forgiveness never says the wound was small. And if forgiveness is release, you can do it before the feelings agree. The hand opens by faith; the heart follows by grace.



Seventy times seven: not a bigger calculator, but the end of calculating. The hand that kept the book opens, and the book goes into the fire.

Living It: Five Practices of Release

1. **Find your page.** You have one. Write the name at the top and, honestly, the entries under it. The ledger does its worst work in the dark.

2. **Name the debt in real terms.** Say what they took: trust, years, a marriage, a reputation. Minimizing it is not forgiveness. It is denial with a Christian label.

3. **Release before you feel like it.** *Aphiēmi* is an act, not a mood. Say it out loud to God: "I send this away. I will not collect." Do it with a clenched heart if that is the only heart you have.

4. **Burn the notebook, not the memory.** You will not forget, and God does not ask you to. He asks you to stop adding entries, stop rehearsing them, and stop bringing them to the next argument as evidence.

5. **Watch for Lamech.** The old instinct to answer a wound with a bigger one is still in you. When you catch yourself building the case for revenge, remember whose number that is.

Part Two: Two Ledgers, The Parable That Answers Peter

> **Matthew 18:23–27** *"Therefore the kingdom of heaven may be compared to a king who wished to settle accounts with his servants. When he began to settle, one was brought to him who owed him ten thousand talents. And since he could not pay, his master ordered him to be sold, with his wife and children and all that he had, and payment to be made. So the servant fell on his knees, imploring him, 'Have patience with me, and I will pay you everything.' And out of pity for him, the master of that servant released him and forgave him the debt."*

Jesus does not leave Peter with a number. He tells him a story with two ledgers in it. The first belongs to a king. A servant is brought in who owes ten thousand talents. Do the math, because Jesus wants you to. A talent was roughly twenty years of a laborer's wages. Ten thousand of them is two hundred thousand years of work, a debt no man could pay in a thousand lifetimes. It is absurd on purpose. And the servant, on his knees, says the most absurd thing in the Bible: "Have patience with me, and I will pay you everything." He still thinks it is a payment problem. Anyone who has ever tried to earn his way back to God knows that sentence from the inside.

Then verse 27, and everything turns on one word.

σπλαγχνίζομαι *(splanchnizomai)*

translated "out of pity" or "moved with compassion." Literally, to be moved in one's inward parts

σπλάγχνα (splanchna)

"the inward parts, the bowels"

To the Greeks, the seat of the deepest feeling. Not the head. Not even the heart. The gut.

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-ίζομαι (-izomai)

verb ending: "to be affected in"

Something happens *to* the master. He is seized from within. This is not a policy decision.

Payoff: The Gospels use this word almost only of Jesus and of the God-figures in His parables: the father who runs to the prodigal (Luke 15:20), the Samaritan on the road (Luke 10:33), and this king. It is God's gut turning over at the sight of a man who cannot pay. Notice the order in verse 27: the master is *moved*, then he *releases* him (*aphiēmi*), then he *forgives the debt* (*aphiēmi* again). Compassion first, then the open hand, then the cancelled account. The servant asked for a payment plan. God does not extend your terms. He tears up the note.

Now the second ledger. The same servant walks out and finds a fellow servant who owes him a hundred denarii, about three months' wages. A real debt, a legal claim. And Jesus, who chose every detail, says he "seized him and began to choke him" (v. 28). The man who was just released grabs a throat. The fellow servant falls to his knees and says, word for word, the plea the first man had said to the king. The forgiven man refuses, and puts him in prison until he should pay.

Feel the ratio, because the whole parable lives in it. Ten thousand talents against a hundred denarii is roughly six hundred thousand to one. Jesus is not saying the hundred denarii was nothing. He is saying that next to what you have been forgiven, the worst thing anyone has ever done to you is a hundred denarii. Not because your wound was small. Because your pardon was enormous.

Here is the sentence to write on your wall. **The unforgiving servant was not a man who had never been forgiven. He was a man who had forgotten it.** He stood on his rights while standing in the freedom of having had his own rights waived. The wonder faded before he reached the street. Unforgiveness is not first a failure of will. It is a failure of memory. The root of bitterness springs up in one kind of soil: a heart that has lost sight of how much it has been forgiven.

And so the ending, which we read fast because it frightens us. The master calls the servant back: "Should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?" Then he delivers him to the jailers, and Jesus adds, "So also my heavenly Father will do to every one of you, if you do not forgive your brother from your heart" (v. 35). Do not soften this, and do not misread it. Jesus is not saying your forgiving *earns* God's forgiving; the king forgave first, freely, out of his gut. He is saying your forgiving *evidences* it. Root and fruit, not price and purchase. A heart that has truly been forgiven a fortune cannot, while the wonder is still warm in it, turn and throttle a brother over a few coins. If it does, something is wrong, not with the arithmetic of salvation but with the reality of it. Settled, cherished unforgiveness in a professing believer is not a small flaw. It is a smoke alarm.

Notice too where the unforgiving man ends up: in prison. That is not a penalty tacked on. It is a description of the thing itself. The unforgiving heart is already in a cell, the lock is on the inside, and the prisoner holds the key. He tells himself his refusal is costing the other man. It is costing him. The offender has gone on with his life. The scorekeeper sits in the dark going over the records, the careful accountant of a debt that is bleeding him dry.



Two ledgers. The one the king closed weighed two hundred thousand years of wages. The one the servant opened in the street weighed three months. He forgot the first before he reached the second.

Living It: Six Moves for the Street Outside the Throne Room

1 **Do the ratio out loud.** Put your worst wound next to your own forgiven debt. Six hundred thousand to one. Say it until the throat you are holding starts to look like a hundred denarii.

2 **Catch yourself at the door.** The servant lost the wonder between the throne room and the street. After the Table, after prayer, after worship, ask before you walk out: "Whose throat am I holding?"

3 **Refuse the payment plan.** "I will pay you everything" is religion without grace. If you are still working off your own debt to God, you will collect every debt owed to you. Receivers forgive. Earners collect.

4 **Drag the arguments into the light.** "Forgiving would say it didn't matter." "Staying angry keeps me safe." "I have a right." Answer each one. Forgiveness declares the wound real and releases it anyway. Bitterness is not armor; it seals the wound in. And the servant had a legal right to his hundred denarii too.

5 **Hear the warning as a diagnosis, not a threat.** When you find a grudge you will not release, do not ask, "Will God still forgive me?" Ask, "Have I forgotten what He already did?" Then go back to the throne room and look.

6 **Check the lock.** Every prison in this parable is locked from the inside. If you are exhausted and replaying a confrontation that never happens, you are not the warden. You are the prisoner. The key is called release.

Part Three: As the Lord Forgave You, The Supply Line

> **Colossians 3:12–13** *"Put on then, as God's chosen ones, holy and beloved, compassionate hearts, kindness, humility, meekness, and patience, bearing with one another and, if one has a complaint against another, forgiving each other; as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive."*

> **Luke 17:3–5** *"If your brother sins, rebuke him, and if he repents, forgive him, and if he sins against you seven times in the day, and turns to you seven times, saying, 'I repent,' you must forgive him. The apostles said to the Lord, 'Increase our faith!'"*

If Part Two is the diagnosis, Part Three is the supply line, because nobody can pour out what he has not first received. Paul, writing to the Colossians, changes the word. He does not use *aphiēmi* here. He reaches for a word built on grace itself.

χαρίζομαι *(charizomai)*

translated "forgiving one another" in Colossians 3:13 and Ephesians 4:32. Literally, to give freely; to grant as a favor; to forgive as a gift

χάρις (charis)

"grace, unearned favor"

The word of the whole gospel: "by grace you have been saved" (Ephesians 2:8). Forgiveness here is grace with a verb ending.

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-ίζομαι (-izomai)

verb ending: "to do, to bestow"

To act out of grace toward someone. Paul uses the same verb when God "graciously gives us all things" with Christ (Romans 8:32).

Payoff: *Aphiēmi* tells you what forgiveness does to the debt: it releases it. *Charizomai* tells you what forgiveness costs and where it comes from: it is a gift, given out of grace, at the giver's expense. And Paul nails the source to the wall with one small word: **καθώς (*kathōs*)**, "just as." Forgive *just as* the Lord forgave you. In the same measure. From the same source. On the same grounds. The command is not "be a forgiving person." The command is "pass along what you were handed." You do not generate this. You receive it and you give it away.

This is why trying harder fails. Anyone who has attempted to forgive by sheer effort knows the root grows back faster than you can pull it. Paul does not leave the command standing alone as a demand of the will. He anchors it in something already done to you before it is asked of you. The kindness he asks for is downstream of the kindness you received. The cure for an unforgiving heart is not to manufacture sweetness from your own depleted reserves. It is to go back to the cross and stand there until the mountain of your own forgiven sin looms so large that the debt you are clutching looks, by comparison, like the few coins it always was.

Then Luke 17 brings it down out of the heroic and into the daily. The same brother, the same day, seven times, and seven times he says, “I repent,” and seven times you must forgive him. No clause for the weary sigh. This dismantles a fantasy most of us carry, that forgiveness is a mountain you climb once. Jesus will not let you keep that picture. Forgiveness in the life He describes is a path walked daily, the same hill before sundown. It is less like a wedding and more like a marriage: not one vow but ten thousand small acts of keeping it, long after the music stops. And that is a relief once you stop resisting it. Many people conclude they failed at forgiveness because the resentment came back a week later. But Jesus never promised that forgiving once would make the feeling vanish. He commanded forgiving seven times in a day precisely because the memory keeps returning, and the forgiving must keep returning to meet it. **The resurgence of resentment is not proof that you never forgave. It is the next occasion for forgiving.**

Look at what the apostles said next. Not “how sensible.” They said, “Increase our faith!” These men had watched Him still storms and raise the dead, and even they heard “seven times a day” and knew at once it was beyond them. They did not ask for more willpower or a better technique. They asked for faith, because forgiveness of this kind is not finally a matter of effort. It requires something we cannot generate. It must be given. That is the posture of every real forgiver: not the strong man flexing, but the weak man holding out an empty cup. The asking is already the beginning of the answer.

One honest distinction before we close, because it protects the wounded. Luke 17 ties the embrace to repentance: “if he repents, forgive him.” Yet from the cross Jesus forgave men who had not repented at all. Both are true, because two things hide under one word. There is the inner *readiness* to forgive, the open hand, the refusal to harbor bitterness. That you always owe, to everyone, whether they ever repent or not. That is *aphiēmi*, and it is what sets you free. And there is full *reconciliation*, restored trust, which takes two and waits on a repentance that may never come. To the woman whose abuser will never acknowledge what he did, the call is not “trust him as before.” The call is: release the bitterness, hand him to the God who hears the cry of the wronged, and refuse to let hatred have your heart. You are not obligated to manufacture a reconciliation the other party has made impossible. But you are invited, for your own sake, to walk out of the cell.



Charizomai: forgiveness as a gift, given out of grace, at the giver's expense. The hand opens because it was first filled.

Living It: Six Habits of the Daily Forgiver

1 **Start at the cross, every time.** Before you try to forgive anyone, rehearse what you were forgiven. Read Psalm 103:12 and Isaiah 43:25 slowly. Forgiveness from your reserves becomes performance. Forgiveness from His becomes worship.

2 **Expect the hill again.** Plan for the resentment to come back at lunch. When it does, you have not failed; you have arrived at the next occasion. The strength is new every morning.

3 **Pray the apostles' prayer.** "Increase my faith" is the only honest response to "seven times a day." Ask for what the command requires, out loud, before the confrontation rather than after you have lost it.

4 **Keep readiness and reconciliation distinct.** Release you owe today, to everyone. Restored trust is rebuilt, not declared, and it takes two. Do not let anyone shame you into the second by calling it the first, and do not dodge the first by hiding behind the second.

5 **Leave the sincerity to God.** By the seventh "I repent" you will suspect a performance. Jesus did not add the qualification you want. Cynicism about every apology is usually not discernment. It is unforgiveness wearing the costume of wisdom.

6 **Forgive in company.** The ledger thrives in isolation. Tell one brother the name at the top of your page and what you are releasing. A grudge said out loud to a forgiven friend loses most of its grip on the spot.

Part Four: One Ledger, Closed

Lay the three passages side by side and the unity is hard to miss. Peter asks about math and Jesus answers with a story about God. The story turns on a king whose gut turns over at a man who cannot pay. And Paul tells the church to do for one another exactly, and only, what was done for them. Three passages, two Greek words, one movement: received, then released.

	The Number Matt. 18:21–22	**The Story** Matt. 18:23–35	**The Source** Col. 3:13 / Luke 17:3–5
The picture	A notebook thrown in the fire; Lamech's number of vengeance turned into a number of mercy	Two ledgers: two hundred thousand years of wages cancelled, three months' wages collected by the throat	A gift passed along; the same hill climbed seven times a day with borrowed strength
Key word	*aphiēmi* = apo + hiēmi: to send away, to release the debt	*splanchnizomai*: moved in the gut; compassion before the cancelled account	*charizomai* = charis + verb: to forgive as a gift, out of grace; *kathōs*, "just as"
What it kills	The limit. The quiet number of chances you were keeping	The forgetting. Walking out of the throne room into the street with the wonder already gone	The trying. Manufacturing forgiveness from your own reserves
The counterfeit	Better bookkeeping: seven instead of three	"I will pay you everything": religion on a payment plan	One heroic act, then despair when the feeling returns
God's part / ours	He sets no limit on His mercy; we stop counting	He is moved, releases, cancels; we remember, and open our hand in the street	He forgave first, fully, as a gift; we pass it on, and ask for the faith to do it again tomorrow
The fruit	A heart with no page open	A man out of the cell he locked from inside	A rhythm: forgiven at dawn, forgiving by noon, free by night

Here is the whole thing in one paragraph. **The number ends the counting:** a figure so large the only response is to burn the book, made by turning the oldest number of revenge into the newest number of mercy. **The story exposes the forgetting:** the man who grabs a throat in the street is not unforgiven; he lost the wonder before the throne-room door shut behind him. **The source supplies the rest:** you forgive *just as* you were forgiven, seven times a day, with faith you keep asking for. Drop any one and the others fail on schedule. A number without the story becomes a new law. A story without the source becomes guilt. A source without the number and the story becomes theology that never reaches the name at the top of your page.

And keep the decisive fact in view. The ledger with your name on it is already closed. "He forgave us all our trespasses, by cancelling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands. This he set aside, nailing it to the cross" (Colossians 2:13–14). The Judge stepped down from the bench and paid the fine Himself, in the person of His Son. That is why He can say, in the doubled certainty of His own name,

“I, I am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake, and I will not remember your sins” (Isaiah 43:25). He does not merely forgive. He, in the deepest biblical sense, forgets to count. And the heart that finally believes that is the only heart free enough, and full enough, to forgive.



Received, then released. A river cannot flow from an empty spring. The forgiven are the only people who can forgive, and they can forgive without end because the spring has no bottom.

For Discussion

1. Peter doubled the rabbis’ number and added one. Where do you keep a quiet, unspoken limit on how many chances someone gets? What would it mean to throw that notebook in the fire?
2. *Aphiēmi* means to release, to send away. How does hearing forgiveness as an act of the hand rather than a feeling of the heart change what you can do this week about the name at the top of your page?
3. The unforgiving servant had a legal right to his hundred denarii. Where are you standing on a genuine right while standing in the freedom of having had your own rights waived? What is the ratio, honestly?
4. Jesus says the unforgiving man ends in prison, and the parable shows the lock is on the inside. What has the score you are keeping cost you: sleep, joy, a relationship, your own body? Who is the actual prisoner?
5. Paul says forgive *just as* the Lord forgave you. When you have tried to forgive by willpower and failed, what were you drawing on? What would it look like to go back to the cross first, and only then to the

person?

6. Luke 17 distinguishes the open hand you always owe from the reconciliation that takes two. Is there a situation where you have confused them, either by refusing to release because they have not repented, or by forcing yourself into a trust that has not been rebuilt? What does freedom look like there?

Sources & For Further Study

- **Text:** Matthew 18:15–35; Genesis 4:23–24; Matthew 6:12–15; Luke 17:3–5; Luke 23:34; Luke 15:20; Luke 10:33; Colossians 2:13–14; 3:12–13; Ephesians 4:31–32; Romans 8:32; Psalm 103:12; Micah 7:19; Isaiah 43:25; Hebrews 8:12; 12:15; 1 John 1:9. English quotations follow the ESV.
- **Greek:** Nestle-Aland 28 / SBLGNT; BDAG on ἀφίημι, ἄφεσις, σπλαγχνίζομαι, χαρίζομαι, χάρις, καθώς, ὀφειλή. Strong's: aphiēmi G863; aphesis G859; splanchnizomai G4697; charizomai G5483; charis G5485; kathōs G2531; opheilēma G3783.
- **Word-study discipline:** D. A. Carson, *Exegetical Fallacies*, on root fallacy; every anatomy above is checked against actual New Testament usage, not etymology alone.
- **Commentaries:** John Calvin, *Commentary on a Harmony of the Evangelists*, on Matthew 18:21–35; R. T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew* (NICNT); Douglas Moo, *The Letters to the Colossians and to Philemon* (Pillar); Martin Luther, *The Ninety-Five Theses*, Thesis 1.
- **Practical:** David S. Jones, *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*, especially chapters 1, 13, 16, and 17, from which this study is drawn; Tim Keller, *Forgive: Why Should I and How Can I?*; John Piper, *Future Grace*, on forgiving as the fruit of faith in what God has done.



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